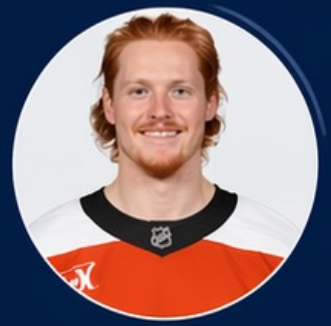
SN
EDM 0
TOR 0
16:44
2 SHOTS 1
1ST
PARLAY
FANDUEL
REHOUSE
HOT TASTES B
14

# Speed is **not** a shortcut

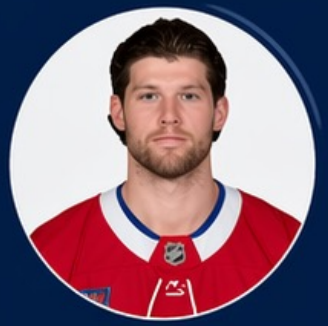
Public tracking data is exciting, but leaderboards need context before they can evaluate hockey performance.

DAT 201 Presentation 2 | Rento Saijo | April 2026

**Connor McDavid**
#1 in points



**Owen Tippett**
#123 in points



**Josh Anderson**
#369 in points

Thesis

# NHL EDGE speed data is publicly interesting but analytically incomplete: without context, speed-burst leaderboards describe a skating trait more than they evaluate performance.

**1** Describe the skating trait

→

**2** Add game context

→

**3** Then judge performance

Without the middle layer, a public speed leaderboard is descriptive, not evaluative.

# Data I used

Two public NHL sources, joined to test whether speed bursts line up with scoring.

## Source A: NHL EDGE

**2025-26 regular-season skater leaderboard for 22+ mph speed bursts.**

- This is public player-tracking output: not raw coordinates, but a curated leaderboard derived from tracking.

## Source B: NHL stats API

**All-skaters points leaderboard for the same season and game type.**

- Joined by player ID, then compared speed-burst rank with points rank.

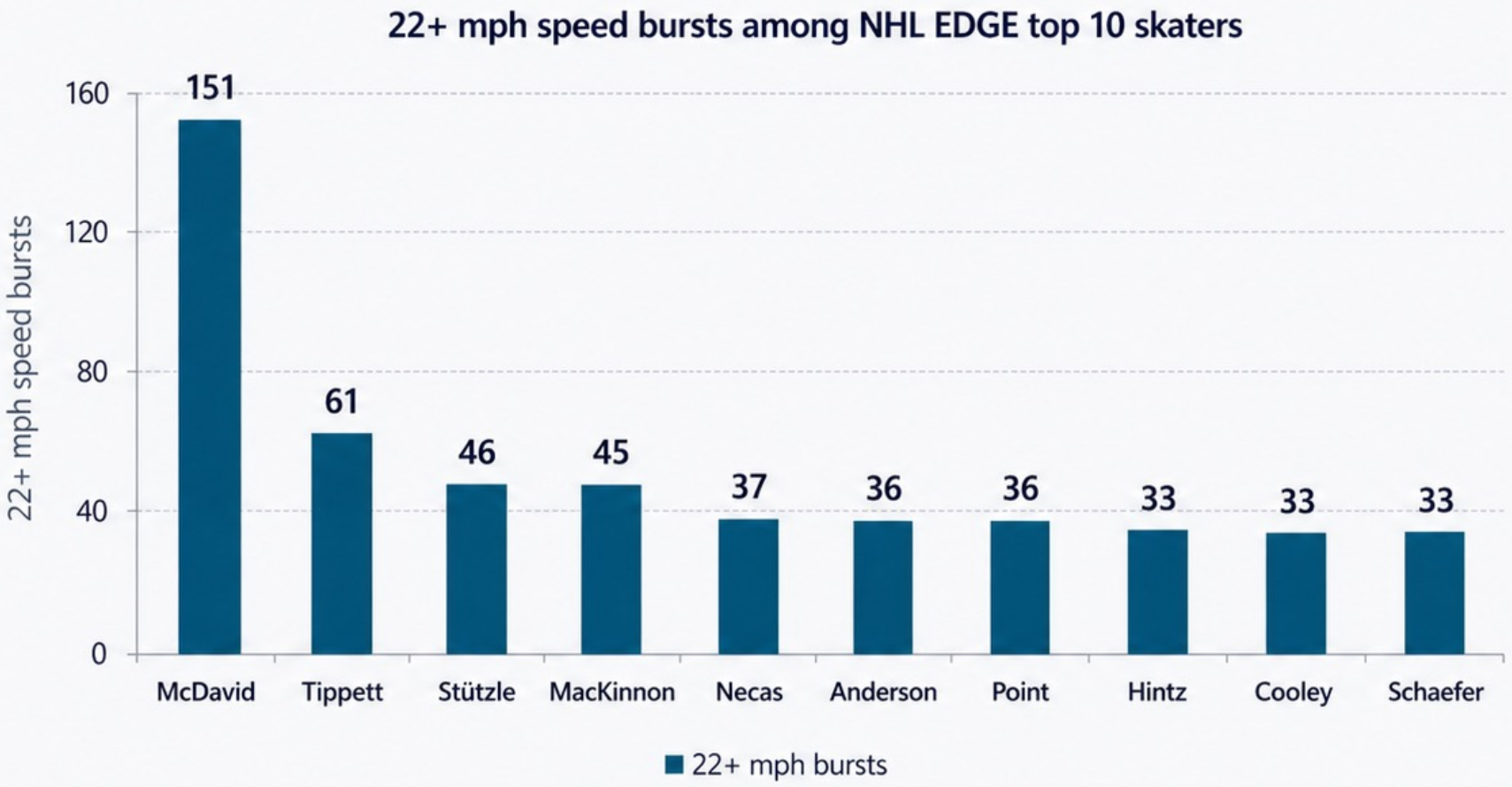
**100** top speed-burst skaters analyzed

**Apr. 24** 2026 data access date

Sources: NHL EDGE skater speed leaderboard and NHL skater stats leaders API, 2025-26 regular season.

# The leaderboard mixes different players

Some speed leaders are elite scorers. Others are far from the top of the scoring table.




KEY READ

## 6 of 10

top speed-burst skaters were outside the top 50 in points.

**Examples scoring rank hides:**

- Owen Tippett: #123 in points
- Josh Anderson: #369 in points
- Brayden Point: #134 in points
- Roope Hintz: #170 in points
- Logan Cooley: #172 in points

Analysis: NHL EDGE 22+ mph speed-burst top 10 joined to NHL 2025-26 points leaders by player ID.

# The scoring link is fragile

Even with 100 top-speed skaters, the data does not support a simple 'more bursts equals more points' story.

**With Connor McDavid included**

**r = 0.63**

bursts vs. points
with Connor McDavid included

vs.

**After removing that one outlier**

**r = 0.24**

bursts vs. points
after removing that one outlier

Analysis: Pearson correlations within the NHL EDGE top-100 22+ mph burst sample; descriptive only, not a league-wide causal estimate.

# A fair counterargument

Speed can still matter away from the scoring table.

## Some bursts create value points miss

- Forecheck pressure
- Controlled zone entries
- Defensive recoveries
- Space for teammates

## Future data I would want

A public shift-level tracking file that connects speed to context and outcome.

Zone entries | Possession changes | Defender gap | Puck-carrier status | Outcome

# Bottom line

NHL EDGE makes tracking data public, but in a curated and simplified form.

The speed leaderboard does not cleanly translate into scoring rank.

Public tracking becomes evaluative only when speed is connected to context and outcome.

DISCUSSION QUESTION

**When leagues publish tracking stats for fans, should they release more leaderboards quickly, or fewer metrics with enough context to prevent overinterpretation?**

Sources: NHL EDGE launch/explainer; NHL EDGE skater speed leaderboard; NHL skater stats leaders API.

OpenAI Images 2.0 was used to enhance the aesthetics of these slides.